

3i. Non-exam assessment – Investigative geography (H481/04, 05)

The A Level Geography component Investigative geography (04/05) is an independent investigation consisting of a written report, recommended to be between 3000 and 4000 words in length.

All learners will be expected to complete an independent investigation which is of their particular personal interest related to any area of the specification – this could be one of the options within Physical systems (01), Human interactions (02) or Geographical debates (03) which they are not studying as part of their teacher-led course.

The independent investigation will consist of a written report which will assess the process of enquiry and investigation. Learning hours are not specified because the process of writing the report is an iterative and independent process, however a length of between 3000 and 4000 words is recommended. Each learner will work at their own pace and time should be made available to explain to learners what is required before they undertake the initial stages of research.

A learner will not be penalised for exceeding the recommended length; however, any response that significantly differs from the recommended length will be self-penalising either by not demonstrating the expectations of the marking criteria to the required level or through lacking coherence and concision.

There will be 60 marks available for the investigation, broken down into six sections. These sections consist of:

1. planning purpose and introduction
2. data, information collection methods and sampling framework
3. data presentation techniques
4. data analysis and explanation
5. conclusions and investigation evaluation
6. overall quality and communication of written work.

Teacher guidance for Investigative geography (04, 05)

It is expected that the teacher will provide guidance to learners in relation to the purpose and requirement of the task. The teacher should ensure that learners are clear about the assessment criteria which they are expected to meet and the skills which they need to demonstrate in the task.

The following section explains the stages at which teachers may give guidance to learners within the independent investigation process and what teachers 'can', 'must' and 'must not' do in relation to providing guidance to learners. The rationale for what teachers 'can', 'must' and 'must not' do in relation to providing guidance to learners is given in Appendix 5d.

Teachers are permitted to give general guidance to learners at two different points in the independent investigation process:

- when learners are choosing an investigation title
- when learners are planning their investigation through the investigation proposal section of the Geography Independent Investigation Form.

Examples of both specific guidance and general guidance are given in Appendix 5e.

Teachers:-

Can:

- provide broad parameters for learners' investigation proposals (including themes from the specification, locations, availability of equipment, time constraints)
- explain to learners what independence means (see table on page 56)
- advise learners on health and safety considerations, the use of equipment and potential ethical concerns
- discuss with learners their initial exploratory planning and tentative investigation titles.

Must:

- confirm that the provisional title has the potential to meet the assessment criteria and offer general guidance on any necessary amendments
- review each learner's Geography Independent Investigation Form. Within this review teachers should ensure that the proposed investigation can suitably access the specification and mark scheme requirements and give general guidance on the methodology that the learner plans to use
- promote good practice such as referencing and using a bibliography system
- store work securely once it is handed in for formal assessment.

Must not:

- provide learners with a choice of titles or tasks from which learners then choose
- give feedback/guidance to individual learners about how to improve work to meet the assessment criteria. This means that teachers must not provide templates and model answers for the work of specific learners
- mark work provisionally and share that mark so that the learner may then improve it
- return work to learners after it has been submitted and marked.

If teachers give any assistance which goes beyond general guidance, for example:

- provide feedback/guidance on how to improve drafts to meet the assessment criteria
- give feedback/guidance on errors and omissions which limits learners' opportunities to show initiative themselves
- intervene personally to improve the presentation or content of work

- provide primary or secondary data not collected by the learner either individually or as part of a group

then teachers **must** record this assistance on the learner/teacher declaration section of the Geography Independent Investigation Form (see page 65) and take it into account when marking the work.

Annotation should be used to explain how marks were applied in the context of the additional assistance given.

If teachers and/or third party fieldwork providers do not record assistance which goes beyond general guidance and take it into account when marking the

work, this will be considered as malpractice. If malpractice is suspected, the Awarding Organisation will investigate. If malpractice is found to have taken place a penalty will be applied dependent on the circumstances and severity of the malpractice.

For full information regarding malpractice please see the JCQ document 'Suspected Malpractice in Examinations and Assessments'.

This section applies also to third party fieldwork providers. Teachers must ensure that at all times they remain confident in the authenticity and independence of each learner's work.

Description of the level of independence at each stage of the investigation

The descriptions in the table below specify the level of independence required by learners at different stages of their investigation; they do not infer anything in the way of marks allocated for each stage of the investigation. The level of independence at each stage is the minimum required (i.e. where collaboration is allowed it is not mandatory and learners may work alone).

Levels of learner independence:

- collaboration allowed - learners may work as a class/group/pair
- independent work – learners must work alone.

If learners collaborate (where independence is expected) and/or are given assistance beyond the parameters indicated in the table below, then the teacher must record this on the Geography Independent Investigation Form and take it into account when marking the work. Failure to do so will be considered as malpractice. If malpractice is suspected, the Awarding Organisation will investigate. If malpractice is found to have taken place a penalty will be given dependent on the circumstances and severity of the malpractice.

For full information regarding malpractice please see the JCQ document 'Suspected Malpractice in Examinations and Assessments'.

Investigation stage	What is the level of independence expected?	What does this level of independence mean in practice at this stage? (The following is not exhaustive)
Exploring focus	Collaboration allowed	Centres may want to give learners a free choice of investigations focusing on any of the compulsory or optional content or they may wish to provide learners with a theme or a range of themes. However, it is not acceptable for learners to choose from a list of titles or investigations provided by the centre (This applies also to third party fieldwork providers. Teachers must ensure that at all times they remain confident in the authenticity and independence of the learner's work). Learners may discuss together, and with their teacher, ideas and research for appropriate geographical questions.

Investigation stage	What is the level of independence expected?	What does this level of independence mean in practice at this stage? (The following is not exhaustive)
Title of the investigation, focus of investigation (sub-questions), purpose of investigation.	Independent work	Following the first stage learners must finalise the draft title of their investigation. This must be done by each learner on his/her own. In the Geography Independent Investigation Form and final written report learners must provide a clear justification and contextualisation of how their enquiry will help them to address their title and explore their theme in relation to the chosen geographical location.
Devising methodology and sampling framework	Collaboration allowed	Learners may collaborate when planning and selecting methodologies/sampling strategies.
Primary data collection	Collaboration allowed	Primary data collection may be carried out individually or in groups.
Secondary data collection	Independent work	Must be carried out independently. Learners select secondary sources of data on their own.
Data/information presentation	Independent work	Learners select and use appropriate data presentation methods on their own.
Data analysis and explanation/interpretation	Independent work	Learners select and use appropriate data analysis techniques and independently interpret and analyse the results on their own.
Conclusions and evaluation	Independent work	Learners evaluate the findings of their investigation and reach a balanced and supported conclusion on their own.

Non-exam assessment marking criteria for Investigative geography (H481/04, 05)

There are a total of 60 marks available for component Investigative geography (04/05). A mark should be awarded for each of the six sections and added together to reach a total out of 60 marks. It is possible that learners may achieve very different marks for each section of the marking criteria, allocate the mark according to the level of competency demonstrated for each area individually.

The marking should be on a 'best fit' principle, if a learner's work meets all criteria in a particular level

this should be awarded the top mark in the level. An answer does not have to meet all the requirements of a level descriptor before being placed in that level. The extent to which it meets all of the requirements of a level descriptor will determine its placement within that level.

The extent to which the statements within the level have been achieved should be the only criteria used when deciding the mark within a level.

